

What else to watch: *Barravento* (1962) ■ *Barren Lives* (1963) ■ *Soy Cuba* (1964) ■ *Entranced Earth* (1967) ■ *Antonio das Mortes* (1969) ■ *El Topo* (1970) ■ *City of God* (2002, pp.304–09) ■ *Carandiru* (2003)



Glauber Rocha Director

Born in Bahia, Brazil, in 1939, Glauber Rocha discovered movies, politics,

and journalism in his teens, quitting law school to pursue filmmaking at 20. Inspired by the French New Wave, he led Brazil's *Cinema Novo* (New Cinema) movement of the 1960s, and competed in the 1964 Cannes film festival with *Black God, White Devil*. This was the first in a class-conscious trilogy that continued with *Entranced*

Earth and *Antonio das Mortes*. Exile in the 1970s saw Rocha shooting in Africa and Spain, and though his views and his experimental style were controversial, he remained a hero at home. Within a year of his final movie, *The Age of the Earth* (1980), he died of a lung infection at 42.

Key movies

1964 *Black God, White Devil*
1967 *Entranced Earth*
1969 *Antonio das Mortes*

salvation and the day when “the dry lands will turn into sea and the sea into dry land.” Rosa continues to question the preacher’s banal utterances, but Manuel follows blindly, carrying out ever more mindless and brutal tasks to satisfy his new master. The Church hierarchy, alarmed by Sebastião and the massacres that are engulfing the region, turn to bounty hunter Antonio das Mortes (Maurício do Valle) to eliminate him.

Absurdist turn

Sebastião is killed, and the fugitive couple press on, stumbling into a camp run by the vicious Captain Corisco (Othon Bastos), the movie’s “white devil,” who rechristens Manuel “Satan” and folds him into his shambolic army of bandits. At this point, the style of the movie

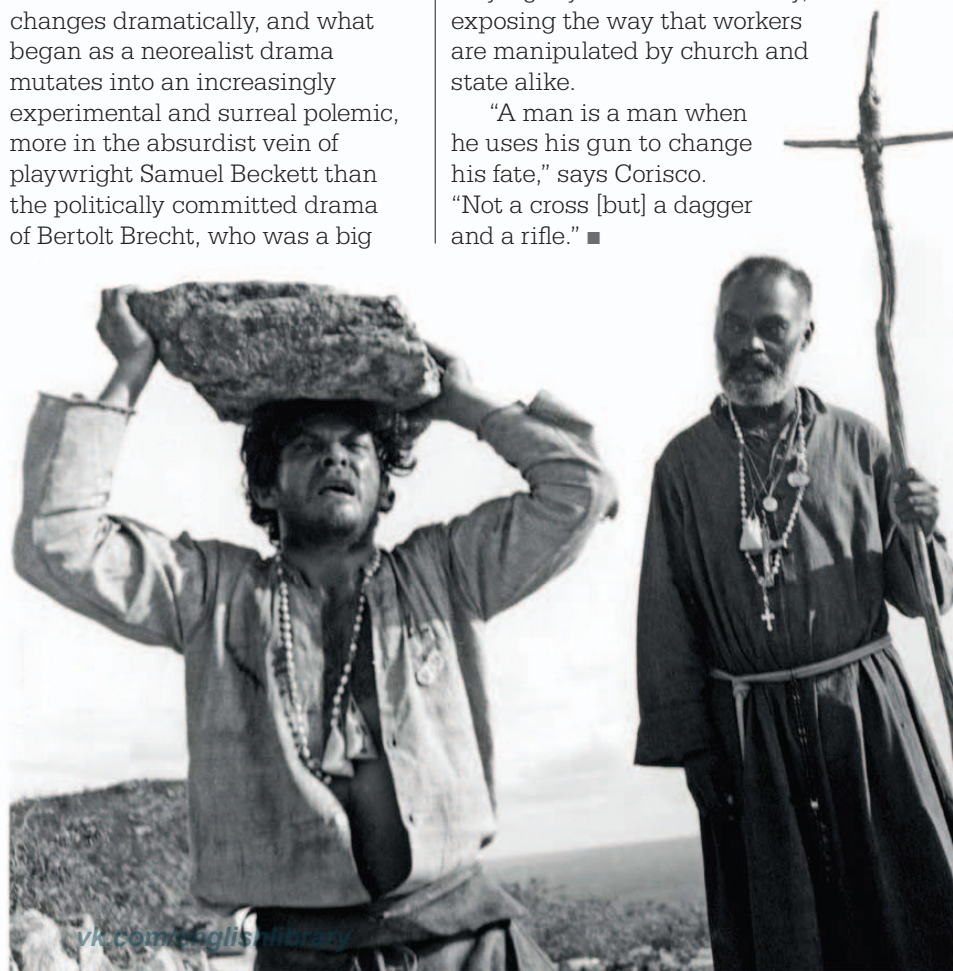
changes dramatically, and what began as a neorealist drama mutates into an increasingly experimental and surreal polemic, more in the absurdist vein of playwright Samuel Beckett than the politically committed drama of Bertolt Brecht, who was a big

influence on Rocha. As the movie draws to a close, the black-clad figure of das Mortes has the almost totally insane Corisco in his sights.

Rallying cry

Sadly, time has not been too kind to Rocha’s movie. The acting often seems mannered or, worse, simply amateur, while the undoubted passion of the director’s vision boils over into moments of thundering melodrama, hammered home by a sometimes overly bombastic score by composer Heitor Villa-Lobos. But in his strange compositions, complete with crash zooms and jump cuts, Rocha created a unique rallying cry for land and liberty, exposing the way that workers are manipulated by church and state alike.

“A man is a man when he uses his gun to change his fate,” says Corisco. “Not a cross [but] a dagger and a rifle.” ■



Manuel (Geraldo Del Rey) carries a rock on his head as he climbs Monte Santo on his knees, in thrall to the preacher Sebastião (Lidio Silva). The rock is loaded with symbolism.